symbolic role of the nascent army in this revolt fed into the mindset of the military after 1948 that the only guarantor of the nation was the military's power and that it faced powerful internal threats.[68]

After the Japanese surrender in August 1945, the BIA waged a low-level insurgency against British rule from 1946 to independence in 1948. Upon independence, it became the core of the new national army.

Shifting demographics in Arakan

Unfortunately, the issue of who actually lived in Arakan in 1824–6 is now a major part of the narrative of extremist Buddhists. The arguments revolve around which ethnic groups were deemed to be part of what is now Myanmar at the date of the British conquest, which has been chosen as the significant historical milestone for deciding which ethnic groups properly belong to which territory. The extremists claim that the Rohingyas only arrived in the region at a later date, due to British influence. This chapter addresses their claims in some detail and engages with the arguments of writers such as Derek Tonkin[69] and Jacques Leider.[70]

As with all nineteenth-century colonial powers, the British needed to keep on top of the demographics of their colonies and so carried out a number of censuses in the region. Though carried out in the interests of the colonial power, these are informative as to the shifting demographics of Arakan and the rest of Burma and provide a substantial amount of evidence, but also, unfortunately, leave some gaps.

As we have seen, Charles Paton carried out a major survey of Arakan in 1825–6. Ostensibly working for the British Colonial Office, he was actually gathering information for Britain's secret spy agencies. But whatever his mission, he left behind a compelling account of life in Arakan in 1826.[71] He detailed the ethnicity of the leaders of various villages and estimated that there were 60,000 Rakhine Buddhists, 30,000 Muslims and 10,000 from other ethnic groups (see Appendix 2).

Paton followed the later British practice of identifying groups as much on the basis of religion as ethnicity. He identified the 'Mugh' with the group more commonly known as the Rakhine but did not subdivide the Muslim population into ethnic groups. But he does make one important and interesting distinction. The local aristocracy ('The Mussalaman Sirdars') are noted as speaking a language easily recognisable to someone who can